

Staff appraisal in higher education — a study of performance review at Nene College, Northampton

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Abstract This paper describes a study of staff appraisal in Higher Education and, in particular, of the appraisal system — called ‘Performance Review’ — at Nene College, Northampton.

The study comprised a review of the recent literature describing some experiences of appraisal systems in a number of British universities and a survey of the opinions of appraisees, appraisers and senior Nene College management with regard to various aspects of the Performance Review system.

In the survey, most appraisees and appraisers thought that appraisers should be line managers rather than peers and that classroom observations should be part of the appraisal system. The opportunity for staff to air views and raise issues during the appraisal interviews was identified as a particular advantage of appraisal for staff. Comparison of the survey findings with the experiences of appraisal in other institutions confirmed that major issues of concern include the importance of organisational commitment; the provision of adequate resources; the effects on the role of heads of departments; the setting and communication of clear, limited goals; consistency of good practice; the provision of adequate follow-up to appraisal interviews and the costs incurred in the operation of appraisal systems.

Introduction

Appraisal in higher education

The need for greater accountability and improved efficiency in British universities has been addressed in the literature since the mid nineteen-seventies (Buss 1975; Clarke and Birt 1982; Shattock 1982). In 1985 the Jarratt Report to the Committee of Vice-Chancellors and Principals (CVCP) proposed that universities should adopt a more systematic and managerial style of governance. In February 1987 the ‘23rd Report’ from Committee ‘A’ of the CVCP (the committee which recommends national salary scales to the Government) stated its commitment to:

the introduction of an appraisal system directed towards developing staff potential, assisting in the improvement of performance and enhancing career and promotion opportunities, thereby improving the performance of the institution as a whole.

As a result, a commitment to systematic staff appraisal was a condition of the 1987 pay settlement. Guidelines were agreed between the CVCP and the Association of University Teachers (AUT) and were published in 1987 (CVCP & AUT, 1987). Further guidelines were published by the CVCP in 1988 (CVCP, 1988).

Implementation of appraisal has been variable. Haslam, Bryman and Webb (1993) following a survey of all British universities and university colleges wrote:

There was a wide variation in appraisal implementationIn the academic year 1989/90 one university was conducting its fifth successive round of appraisal, while at the other extreme a number of universities had yet to conduct pilot schemes or fix a timetable for the introduction of appraisal.....At the end of the research (August/September 1991)....the majority of universities had reached at least their second round of appraisal interviews

In the former polytechnics and HE colleges, there is no direct national requirement for appraisal. There has, however, been a requirement for such institutions to include an element of Performance Related Pay (PRP) in pay agreements and a recommendation that this be linked to staff appraisal.

In March 1991, during a dispute on pay and conditions between the employers and the trade unions, the Secretary of State wrote to the Polytechnic and Colleges Employers' Forum (PCEF) indicating that the DES would withhold 2% (£13,000,000) from the sector's 1991/2 provision unless an undertaking was given to:

...introduce greater flexibility into the pay structure so as to reward performance and productivity

For the 1992/3 pay round, the Government's requirements were more specific — £13,000,000 was to be withheld unless the employers agreed to allocate 0.75% of the provision for salaries to performance related pay.

Guidelines for the introduction of PRP published by the PCEF (PCEF, 1991) and circulated to all polytechnics and HE colleges offered advice on the definition, measurement and ranking of performance. With regard to appraisal, the Guidelines stated simply that:

There should be a positive link between performance related pay and staff appraisal.

As in the traditional universities, progress in the former polytechnics and HE colleges was variable. Some decided to introduce appraisal schemes in advance of the government requirement for PRP, some have introduced it as a result of the PRP requirement and some may not yet have introduced it at all.

Establishing the rationale

One of the problems facing institutions of Higher Education when introducing appraisal schemes was that of establishing a rationale and hence determining the criteria upon which such a scheme would be based. There were three particular factors which contributed to this difficulty.

Firstly, whilst a widely-held view of appraisal is that it should not be linked to pay (Randall et al. 1984; Fidler 1989; Pennington and O'Neil 1988), the commitment to appraisal in the case of the traditional universities and the link between performance related pay and appraisal in the case of the former polytechnics and colleges were *conditions of pay agreements*.

Secondly, appraisal schemes were, in some cases introduced rapidly (Helm 1989; Fox 1994). Thirdly, although guidelines for the setting up of appraisal systems

were issued to the traditional universities, no guidance was offered to the former polytechnics and colleges.

An early attempt to apply principles drawn from the literature to the specific case of appraisal in Higher Education institutions was made by Pennington and O'Neil (1988). They identified the fundamental characteristics of an appraisal scheme, the organisational prerequisites, the aspects of lecturers' roles which should be appraised, the conditions for successful appraisal interviews and the benefits claimed for appraisal.

Some experiences of appraisal in higher education

Since the satisfactory development of appraisal schemes requires a lead time of at least two years (Trethowan 1987; Fidler 1992) and the introduction of appraisal into HE is recent, it may be too early to evaluate its effectiveness. Nevertheless, there is recent literature which evaluates the introduction of appraisal schemes in universities and some which evaluates their introduction *and* the early stages of their implementation.

The University of Liverpool

Helm (1989) described the "*Speedy introduction of a scheme of Staff Development and Appraisal for academic staff at the University of Liverpool in 1987/88.*" He described the process of consultation and negotiation involved in gaining acceptance of the scheme and wrote that external consultants were engaged to provide appraisal training for Heads (appraisers).

Whilst having recognised that it was too early to begin to evaluate the scheme, Helm identified a number of "*lessons (which) have already emerged*":

The Scheme has been put into place relatively painlessly for four reasons: strong support from the leadership of the University; the general commitment made in the 23rd Report; the appraisal scheme was introduced at a time when the whole of the University's resourcing arrangements were being overhauled; and a deliberate and somewhat novel process of wide and informal consultation among staff.

The Scheme.....highlights the increased responsibilities of heads of department...and (the need for) providing support and training.

The University of Birmingham

Rutherford (1992) described the introduction of a staff appraisal scheme at the University of Birmingham. As was the case at Liverpool University, external consultants who had an industrial background were used to provide one-day

workshops for appraisers. Unlike the Liverpool experience, briefing workshops were also provided for appraisees.

Like Helm, Rutherford identified the increased responsibility of heads of schools, writing:

The main burden of implementing the staff development and appraisal scheme has fallen on the heads of schools, reinforcing their line management responsibilities.....Heads of schools are now regarded, certainly by the University of Birmingham, very much as line managers and rather less as leading professionals.....It is hardly surprising that developing the leadership capabilities of heads of schools has been recognised as an urgent priority in the University.

Rutherford examined the introduction of appraisal at Birmingham University in terms of, "*Six decisive factors: linkage, openness, gain/loss, ownership, leadership and power*". He concluded that:

1. Without the exercise of *power* from the policy domain (that is, government) the scheme would never have got off the ground.
2. There was also determined *leadership* from some senior academics.
3. There was initially very little sense of *ownership*....This may explain....the hostility that was evident at many of the briefing meetings for appraisees.
4. Initially, *losses* were more obvious...The *gains* had to be taken on trust.
- 5 & 6. The scheme was piloted in a number of departments and there was much discussion in departmental meetings and at Senate. This all illustrates the value of *linkage* and *openness*.

He finally predicted that:

The Staff Development and Appraisal scheme should make an important contribution to the continuing success of the institution by ensuring a harmony between, on the one hand, individual needs and aspirations and, on the other hand, school and University development plans.

The University of Ulster

In terms of evaluating appraisal schemes which were 'up and running', a recent account of a study of a system of appraisal in operation was provided by Barry Hutchinson of the University of Ulster (Hutchinson 1993).

Hutchinson conducted an undisclosed number of semi-structured interviews between May 1991 and June 1992 with staff at all levels including the Pro-Vice-Chancellor (Personnel), the Staffing Officer, Deans, Heads of Departments, 'ordinary' and 'junior' members of staff (these terms were not defined).

In reporting his work (Hutchinson 1993), he quoted extensively from interview transcripts but made no attempt to quantify responses and drew, "*only limited conclusions on particular issues*".

He identified (but did not discuss, expand upon or indicate the extent to which they were seen as problematic) '*many of the particular issues*' as:

- the absence of "good practice" in departments
- the inadequate training of junior staff

- the ratio of appraisees to appraisers
- the variations and exceptions in procedures
- the failure to appraise everyone
- the misunderstandings and misconceptions
- the reliance on interviews based on the desk-top completion of pro-forma's
- the inadequacy of follow-up.

Hutchinson commented that:

One possible common characterisation of.....the particular issuesis that they all represent failures in realising the University's intentions in practice.

A study of appraisal in several universities

The most comprehensive work to date on staff appraisal in universities is that of Haslam, Bryman and Webb (1992; 1993a; 1993b) who conducted a DES-funded research project in which they examined the introduction of performance appraisal in British universities.

Between 1989 and 1990 the authors examined, "*academic opinion regarding the introduction of staff appraisal in two universities prior to the implementation of appraisal schemes*". (Haslam et al. 1992). They wrote that:

Staff were in favour of appraisal where they believed the emphasis of the scheme was on individual staff development. They expected staff appraisal to benefit them in terms of clarifying expectations and providing useful feedback. Additionally, they felt that systematic appraisal may result in greater accountability, improved motivation through the recognition of good performance and the identification of training needs. However, some thought that the appraisal process would be very time-consuming and costly to administer and that it could have adverse effects on staff morale if the identified training needs are not met. Many noted that the appraisal process is not backed up by sufficient opportunities for career advancement and were therefore sceptical about its potential for greater efficiency and improved staff performance.

The post-appraisal phase of the work comprised a national telephone survey of all universities and university colleges followed by four in-depth case studies in selected universities.

The case studies were designed to establish the aims and objectives of the schemes and examine the impact of the appraisal process and were carried out using questionnaires and interviews with appraisers, appraisees and senior managers. The questionnaires and semi-structured interview schedules were piloted at a university which was not the subject of a case study.

Two of the case studies were in the universities in which the pre-appraisal work was conducted. In each of the case-study universities two academic-related and eight academic departments were targeted. Two of the universities were working on annual appraisal interview cycles, although one had delayed the second round for over eighteen months, one had a biennial scheme and the fourth had not conducted one full round.

The response rate to the questionnaires was between 49% and 57% which the authors described as, “*slightly disappointing*”. They reported that comments received from respondents suggested that many were overwhelmed by paperwork and that many were largely uninterested in appraisal. 26% of respondents were appraisers (as well as being appraisees) and 6% were involved in devising the appraisal schemes.

On the basis of the questionnaire responses and interviews, the authors concluded that:

Staff did not find the procedure very useful in clarifying expectations or in formulating their own aims and objectives...

there was major concern regarding the lack of follow-up to the interviews...

where it was impossible for heads of department to conduct all interviews, findings should be relayed back so that he/she has an overview of the management and resource implications...

many believed it was time-consuming and costly for universities...

it has had minimal effect on staff motivation and performance...

And in summary:

From the present research it is clear that virtually all universities have responded to the need to develop systematic staff appraisal schemes. But so far, at least, the appraisal process seems largely decoupled from the mainstream activities of universities.

Discussion

In introducing appraisal into higher education it will inevitably be exposed to academic scrutiny and analysis to an extent which may not be the case in other areas of human endeavour. Whilst this may provide the opportunity for appraisal to eventually be developed and evaluated in the most appropriate and effective way, it would be unfortunate, in terms of the smooth introduction of appraisal, if the lessons drawn from the theory and from experience in other areas were not taken into account.

There is some evidence that there is a danger that this may be the case. If it is so, then it is probably due to the fact that for most institutions, the main impetus for the introduction of appraisal was external pressure — what Richardson called the ‘*power domain*.’. Furthermore, in some cases, appraisal schemes were introduced rapidly (Helm 1989; Fox 1994) and in others, they may not have enjoyed the whole-hearted support of senior management (Halsam et al. 1993).

Whilst the literature stresses the importance of clear and limited goals (Pennington & O’Neil 1988; Helm 1989; Hutchinson 1993); Haslam et al. (1993a & b) wrote of:

A widespread ambiguity surrounding the intentions of performance appraisal in universities.

The lack of resources both to support the appraisal process and to meet development needs identified in appraisal emerged as a major concern in all of the

studies reviewed. Since the perceived commitment of leadership to the process was seen as being crucial to the success of an appraisal scheme (Pennington and O'Neil 1988; Helm 1989; Rutherford 1992), failure to provide the necessary resources for appraisal may additionally be seen as a manifestation of lack of institutional commitment.

The lack of follow-up to the appraisal interview was identified as a major concern by Haslam *et al.* (1993a & b) and by Hutchinson (1993).

All of the work in British universities identified the increased responsibilities of heads of departments as a consequence of appraisal and the possibility of this leading to a change in the nature of their roles. Furthermore, the importance of training for appraisers was emphasised by Helm (1989), Rutherford (1992) and Hutchinson (1993).

This is supported by work carried out in Australia by Ingrid Moses (1989). A survey of heads of departments in eight Australian universities highlighted, based upon 159 responses, the "*difficulties of heads who have to make evaluative statements on departmental staff*". Moses wrote that:

Regular performance appraisal of tenured staff pose particular problems (for heads)

Following a second survey of an undisclosed number of academic staff but which elicited 283 responses, Moses wrote that 28% of staff had found their head "less than satisfactory" or "quite unsatisfactory" in carrying out appraisals.

Conclusions

The research reported to date has shown that staff appraisal is now an established fact of life in British Higher Education. However, there is no clear consensus in the literature as to its overall usefulness.

Indeed, there was a clear difference in summative view between those researchers who had some direct involvement in the introduction or operation of appraisal schemes and those who did not.

In the case of the former, Helm (1989) described appraisal as:

....an important element in the management of the University;

Rutherford (1992) wrote:

The Staff Development and Appraisal scheme should make an important contribution to the continuing success of the institution...

and Hutchinson (1993) wrote:

First of all, what appears not to be an issue at all is recognition and acceptance of the need for appraisal...

On the other hand, Haslam, Bryman and Webb (1993a) wrote:

There was little evidence to suggest that staff found appraisal very useful. Indeed, many believed that the exercise was time-consuming and costly for universities with little tangible benefit.

As stated earlier, it is probably too early to reliably evaluate the effectiveness of appraisal in Higher Education. The conflicting views of those who have attempted to do this so far support this contention.

Appraisal at Nene College

Nene College is a university sector college of higher education. It offers a wide range of undergraduate and postgraduate courses and supports a growing level of research activity. Its degree programmes are presently validated by the University of Leicester although the College has recently acquired degree-awarding powers for taught courses. Its staff profile is broadly comparable to that of the 'new' universities.

In December 1990 — in anticipation of the Government's requirement for performance-related pay but cognisant of the commitment to appraisal in the University sector — the College established a working group on staff 'performance review and development procedures'. In January 1991 the group issued guidelines for the introduction of an appraisal scheme based on annual interviews. The scheme was described as:

a review of an individual's performance and a mechanism for planning future development on an individual, departmental and college basis.

A list of designated reviewers (appraisers) was proposed by Deans and training was provided through a series of one-day workshops conducted by staff of the College's Faculty of Management and Business. The first round of interviews was held in October and November 1991. Successive interview rounds were held in the Summer Term of each academic year and four rounds have now been completed. Revised guidelines were issued in 1992 and again in 1993.

Key features of the scheme were that:

- The objectives were to be the review of performance, setting of objectives and identification of staff development needs.
- Appraisal was to be by line managers or their nominees
- Where poor performance was identified, it was to be separated from the performance review scheme and was to be dealt with through the College's disciplinary procedure.

Preparation for interviews was to be by means of three pro-forma's. One was to be completed by the reviewer and one by the reviewee and these were to be exchanged at least one week before the interview. The third pro-forma was to be completed at interview, agreed and signed by both reviewer and reviewee and was to be considered the definitive appraisal document. One copy of the agreed pro-

forma was to be given to the reviewee, one held within the Faculty and one held by the Personnel Officer.

Systematic classroom observations were introduced at the same time as appraisal — every lecturer was to be observed twice per year, once by their line manager and once by a peer — but the guidelines stated that these *were not* part of the appraisal scheme.

The survey

The purpose of the survey was to examine the Performance Review (staff appraisal) system for academic staff at Nene College. The survey was carried out after the completion of three whole rounds (cycles) of the system and the interview phase of the fourth round.

Methodology

The research tools used were the questionnaire and the semi-structured interview.

Questionnaires were circulated to appraisers and appraisees in three of the College's four faculties. The fourth faculty was omitted from the survey since it had, until recently, provided most of the College's further education courses so that, unlike the other faculties, its staff were atypical of those of a higher education institution. Questionnaires were distributed through the College's internal mail system to all appraisers in the three faculties, a total of 46, and to 95 appraisees — approximately 25% of the population. The appraisees were selected by choosing every fourth name from an alphabetical listing of academic staff in each of the three faculties. Although appraisers were also subject to appraisal by their line managers, the rubric to the questionnaires to appraisers specifically requested their opinions as appraisers and not as appraisees.

Approximately 10% of respondents from each group were interviewed and, additionally, in order to provide a College view, the Deputy Director was interviewed.

The use of two research tools — questionnaires and interviews — and the involvement of three populations — appraisees, appraisers and senior management — was also intended to provide a degree of triangulation in the analysis of responses.

The questionnaires were designed to elicit opinions regarding

- the purpose of appraisal
- the benefits of appraisal to participants and to management
- the effectiveness of the appraisal system
- the effectiveness of the appraisal interview
- participants' expectations of the system

- the extent to which objectives set in appraisal are perceived to be met
- the main inhibiting factors in meeting objectives and development needs
- whether there is a preference for peer appraisal or for line management appraisal
- the perceived role of classroom observations in appraisal

Appraisees and appraisers were asked the same questions but worded appropriately to their different perspectives. The questions were presented in the form of statements, respondents being required to circle one number of four to indicate the extent of their agreement with the statement.

1 = strongly disagree

2 = disagree

3 = agree

4 = strongly agree

The questionnaires were piloted with the assistance of ten appraisees from the survey population who did not then participate in the actual survey and by three appraisers from the faculty which was omitted from the survey proper.

The interviews were designed primarily to allow interviewees to respond in more detail to a number of the research questions than was permitted by questionnaires. For this reason, interviews were semi-structured and took the form of a reiteration of a number of the research questions followed by, "How/Why not?" or, "Why?". Additionally, the author sought to use the interviews to determine reasons for the poor response from appraisees to the questionnaires.

The interview with the Deputy Director was intended to elicit the College's 'official' viewpoint and, therefore, took the form of a 'Specialised interview', tailored to the particular post-holder.

All of the interviews were conducted during a three-week period in July 1994.

Results

95 questionnaires were distributed to appraisees and 46 to appraisers. Second copies were distributed to initial non-respondents and the final total number of completed questionnaires was 45 (47%) in the case of appraisees and 34(76%) in the case of appraisers. Six appraisee and three appraiser respondents were subsequently interviewed as was the Deputy Director.

The level of response to the questionnaires, although disappointing, was not inconsistent with that reported by Haslam, Bryman and Webb (1993a & b). In their survey of four universities, the overall response was a "slightly disappointing" 49 – 57%. Their survey included both appraisees and appraisers. Comparing the Nene College survey on the same basis, taking into account both appraisees (47%) and appraisers (76%), the overall response was 56%.

In interviews, the reasons suggested for the poor response to appraisee questionnaires were:

High staff workload
 Busy time of year
 Too much paperwork already
 Too many questionnaires
 Questionnaires (generally) seen as unimportant

The reasons reported by Haslam, Bryman and Webb for the poor response to questionnaires in their work were:

High staff workload
 Too much paperwork already
 Staff uninterested in appraisal

Interestingly, none of the interviewees in the Nene College work offered disinterest in appraisal as a reason for the poor response.

Significant majorities of both appraisee and appraiser respondents agreed that the *purposes of appraisal* include:

- an indicator of performance — 80% of appraisees,
67% of appraisers
- the setting of objectives — 93% of appraisees,
97% of appraisers
- the identification of development needs — 89% of appraisees,
97% of appraisers.

Other purposes offered by interviewees were that it was a requirement of Government and an 'accepted' management procedure. The Deputy Director indicated that the College view was that the main purpose of appraisal was to facilitate staff development and link it to College or faculty plans.

The *benefits of appraisal to staff* were agreed to include:

- the opportunity to discuss problems — 74% of appraisees,
94% of appraisers
- the recognition of achievements — 66% of appraisees,
100% of appraisers
- the addressing of weaknesses — 65% of appraisees,
85% of appraisers
- the setting of objectives — 91% of appraisees,
97% of appraisers
- the identification of development needs — 80% of appraisees,
100% of appraisers

There was strong feeling amongst interviewees that a major benefit of appraisal is that it provides:

....the opportunity to air views and grievances

....a rare chance to speak one-to-one with my line manager

....my only chance to tell my line manager what I think

....the opportunity for staff to talk with their line manager, sometimes for the first time when appraisal was first introduced.

The only issue on which there was general agreement regarding the *benefits of appraisal to management* was that it:

- identifies staff development needs — 91% of appraisees,
97% of appraisers

There was marginal agreement that appraisal:

- would improve staff performance — 50% of appraisees,
67% of appraisers
- was cost-effective — 50% of appraisees,
59% of appraisers

There was general agreement that appraisal *does not*:

- identify course needs — 62% of appraisees,
62% of appraisers
- improve students' learning experience — 81% of appraisees,
58% of appraisers

Other benefits identified in interview were the linking of staff development to College needs and improvement in staff morale.

With regard to the *implementation of the Nene College appraisal ('performance review') system*, there was general agreement that:

- the pro-forma's were helpful — 57% of appraisees,
71% of appraisers
- the interviews were useful — 81% of appraisees,
97% of appraisers
- the appraiser should be a line manager rather than a peer — 70% of appraisees,
97% of appraisers
- classroom observations should be part of the system — 68% of appraisees,
91% of appraisers
- the system was satisfactory overall — 52% of appraisees,
70% of appraisers

There was general agreement that the College *does not* provide:

- adequate follow-up — 52% of appraisees,
68% of appraisers
- sufficient information — 73% of appraisees,
59% of appraisers

The inadequacy of information was illustrated by the fact that 55% of appraisees and 52% of appraisers wrongly thought that classroom observations were part of the appraisal system.

Regarding participants' *expectations of appraisal*, there was agreement that it would:

- improve appraisees' feeling of involvement — 52% of appraisees,
84% of appraisers
- increase staff workload — 53% of appraisees,
55% of appraisers

There was agreement that it *would not*:

- improve promotion prospects — 86% of appraisees,
77% of appraisers
- decrease staff workloads — 93% of appraisees,
87% of appraisers

Opinion was divided as to whether appraisal would improve job satisfaction (64% of appraisees thought that it would not; 64% of appraisers thought that it would) or improve job performance (56% of appraisees thought that it would not; 67% of appraisers thought that it would).

Responses towards the *appraisal interviews* were comprehensively positive, large majorities agreeing that both appraisees and appraisers were well-prepared, appraisees' views were actively sought, appraisees felt free to express their ideas and concerns, achievements were recognised and development needs and objectives were agreed.

There was agreement that:

- objectives set in appraisal were achieved — 74% of appraisees,
82% of appraisers
- development needs identified were met — 53% of appraisees,
58% of appraisers

Majorities felt that the *main factors preventing objectives being met* were:

- appraisees' workloads too high — 78% of appraisees,
81% appraisers

The *main factors preventing development needs being met* were agreed to be:

- appraisees' workloads too high — 83% of appraisees,
79% of appraisers
- insufficient funding — 68% of appraisees,
67% of appraisers

Discussion

The findings of studies of appraisal systems in HE institutions have been varied. Comparison with the findings of this study are not, therefore, an issue of whether or not the findings agree but, rather, where the findings of this study sit on the continuum of opinion.

The question of staff acceptance of the need for appraisal exemplifies this point. Hutchinson (1993) wrote that, "*what appears not to be an issue at all is recognition and acceptance of the need for appraisal*". Haslam, Bryman and Webb (1993a & b) reported a generally negative view of appraisal and concluded that, "*so far, at least, the appraisal process seems largely decoupled from the mainstream activities of universities*".

The perceptions of participants in the Nene College study were generally positive towards appraisal, a range of significant benefits being recognised for both staff and the institution. Furthermore, there was general agreement that the system was time-cost effective whereas Haslam, Bryman and Webb wrote that "*many believed that it was time-consuming and costly*".

Organisational commitment to appraisal was identified as a necessary prerequisite for the success of an appraisal system by Helm (1989), Rutherford (1992) and Hutchinson (1993).

Some doubt as to the degree of commitment of senior management to the Nene College system was reported by Fox (1994) and by some of the interviewees in this study. However, the generally positive view of appraisal and the overall satisfaction with the system revealed in this study bring into question the importance of a *strong* organisational commitment. In view of the Nene College experience, it may be that appraisal systems can succeed without a strong organisational commitment, provided that there is sufficient support in terms of structure and resources.

The importance of clear goals was underlined by all of the studies of appraisal in practice. Hutchinson wrote of concerns about, "*misunderstandings and misconceptions*" and Haslam, Bryman and Webb wrote of, "*a widespread ambiguity*".

Whilst, in general, the goals of the Nene system were clear and were understood, there was some confusion as to the status of classroom observations in appraisal.

Haslam, Bryman and Webb wrote that appraisal "*has a minimal effect on staff motivation and performance*".

A majority of appraisees in this study agreed that appraisal would not improve performance, morale or motivation although a majority of appraisers thought that it would, reflecting the generally more positive view of appraisers.

The lack of resources available to meet development needs identified in appraisal was reported as, "*a concern expressed by the staff unions*" by Helm. Both appraisees and appraisers in the Nene College study concurred that this was a problem.

All of the studies of appraisal systems in other institutions made reference to fundamental changes in the role of heads of department as a result of their involvement in appraisal. This was not identified as an issue in this study.

The reason for this difference may be that all of the other studies were of appraisal systems in 'traditional' universities where the role of heads has been very clearly as academic leaders and less as line managers. On the other hand, in the former Polytechnics and Colleges sector (the 'new' universities), which includes Nene College, the emphasis has been rather more towards the line management role.

Conclusions

Staff appraisal has now been a feature of life in Higher Education for about four years. In this relatively short time it has already been subjected to considerable scrutiny through the studies referred to in this work. Nevertheless, it is still early to make definitive judgements of a management system which:

- may take some years to become fully established (as exemplified by the number of times the Nene College Guidelines have been revised)
- is intended to generate benefits many of which are of a long-term nature.

The rather mixed views of appraisal reported so far may be due to the newness of appraisal in Higher Education. However, there is another factor which should not be overlooked and that is the possibility of unintentional bias on the part of some researchers.

It is clear from the literature that researchers who examined the *introduction* of appraisal systems were, on the whole, more positive regarding its potential benefits than were those researchers who examined appraisal after periods of its operation. Furthermore, the former group of researchers were actively involved in the setting up of appraisal schemes in their institutions whereas the latter group were not (as far as could be determined from their writings).

It should also be noted that, in this research, appraisers were found to have more positive views of appraisal than appraisees and that the author of this work is an appraiser as defined for purposes of the study.

In spite of the mixed views of appraisal overall, there were several issues on which there was a high degree of, if not general consensus in the literature, and which was confirmed by the Nene College study. These were identified in some cases as concerns and in others as problems. The issues were:

- the importance of organisational commitment to the scheme
- the provision of adequate resources to meet both the training needs of appraisers and the development needs of appraisees identified in appraisal
- the need to address the changing roles of heads of department brought about partly as a result of their responsibilities as appraisers
- the importance of setting clear, limited goals and communicating these to participants
- consistency of good practice in carrying out appraisal

- the provision of adequate follow-up to the appraisal interviews
- awareness of the cost to institutions in both financial terms and in terms of time spent in carrying out appraisal.

Additional issues specifically identified in the Nene College study were:

- the importance of the appraisal interviews as an opportunity for staff to air views and raise problems
- the belief that classroom observations should be part of the appraisal process
- the preference for appraisers to be line managers rather than peers.

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